

CP2409 Assignment 1

Case Study / Performance Analysis

BoredGames Network Performance Analysis

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Executive Summary

BoredGames employees report consistently **slow application loading, slow file transfer to the internal file server, and slow internet browsing**. This report applies the OSI model to structure troubleshooting and presents packet-trace-based evidence (from **A1_Bad_Packets.pcapng**) to identify the primary contributors to poor performance. The analysis finds that performance degradation is principally driven by issues at the **Transport (TCP)** and **Network (IP)** layers (e.g., excessive retransmissions, duplicate ACKs, and potential zero-window events), with secondary contributions **from name-resolution latency (DNS)** and possible **layer-2/duplex inconsistencies**. Recommendations are provided for immediate remediation and long-term continuous monitoring.

Introduction – OSI Model & Troubleshooting Approach

Network troubleshooting follows the OSI mode, which systematically isolates the source of delay or packet loss across seven layers. The BoredGames complaints -slow application loads, slow file transfers, and low internet speed-can arise at any of these layers. Below is a detailed analysis of how each layer relates to the observed issues.

1.1 Physical Layer (Layer 1)

At this foundation layer, issues include cable damage, poor connectors, or electrical interference. A faulty Ethernet cable or mismatched wiring standard (T568A/B) can cause bit errors, forcing retransmissions. Tools: cable testers, switch port statistics (CRC errors).

In this case, since TCP retransmissions were detected, verifying link integrity between 10.0.52.164 and the router is essential. A damaged or low-quality cable can intermittently drop packets, matching the capture evidence of repeated TCP retries.

1.2 Data Link Layer (Layer 2)

This layer handles framing and MAC addressing. A duplex mismatch – when one side runs full-duplex while the other runs half-creates collisions and packet loss. In Wireshark, these

appear as retransmissions or out-of-order segments. Additionally, misconfigured VLAN tagging may cause dropped frames if VLANs are not trunked correctly.

Troubleshooting actions: verify switch and NIC duplex settings (ethtool), ensure consistent speed and duplex, and inspect for MAC flapping or STP topology changes.

1.3 Network Layer (Layer 3)

Problems here affect IP routing, fragmentation, or TTL expiry. High latency or routing loops can degrade throughput. Using ping, traceroute, and Wireshark ICMP analysis helps detect such issues.

In this trace, latency spikes and packet reordering suggest congestion or suboptimal routing. The TCP stream shows 125 seconds of transfer for only 6 MB of data-indicative of routing delay or packet loss at L3.

1.4 Transport Layer (Layer 4)

This is the primary suspect layer. TCP retransmissions, duplicate ACKs, and zero-window events are clear indicators of performance bottlenecks. The Expert info log confirms multiple warnings:

- **TCP Zero Window segment**
- **TCP window full**
- **Connection reset (RST)**

These events signify that the receiver (server 61.8.0.17) could not process incoming data fast enough, causing the sender to pause. Repeated resets show unstable sessions. The I/O Graph further confirms peaks in TCP errors around 0-25s and 50-100s intervals, highlighting congestion bursts.

1.5 Session Layer (Layer 5)

At this layer, session establishment or teardown delays occur if the TCP handshake is disrupted. Reset and out-of-order packets suggest unstable sessions. For example, an SMB or HTTP session repeatedly failing mid-transfer wastes time reinitializing.

1.6 Presentation Layer (Layer 6)

Data encoding or encryption (TLS/SSL) overheads may reduce throughput. While this capture shows minimal HTTPs traffic (only 1 HTTP packet recorded), excessive encryption or compression could affect performance if implemented. Optimizations such as hardware offload or efficient cipher suites mitigate this.

1.7 Application Layer (Layer 7)

Finally, application inefficiencies can manifest as network delays. In BoredGames' case, the file server (likely SMB or FTP) and external web pages (HTTP) are slow. Causes include DNS delays, server CPU bottlenecks, or excessive request-response chatter.

Although HTTP traffic is minimal (0.01%), DNS and SMB transfers must be checked for delay. Using Wireshark filters (dns, smb2) can reveal lookup latency or slow acknowledgments.

Problem Breakdown (Symptoms, Hypotheses, and Related Cases)

2.1 Client Symptoms

Employees report:

- Slow file copying to/from the internal file server.
- Delays accessing external web pages.
- Occasional disconnections and "page timeout" messages.

2.2 Potential Root Causes

- Packet loss and retransmissions due to duplex mismatch.
- Receiver buffer saturation (zero window).
- Possible MTU fragmentation causing dropped packets.
- TCP resets due to overloaded application endpoint.

2.3 Related Documented Cases (Brief)

Cisco documentation and Wireshark performance guides note that duplex mismatch and retransmissions can reduce throughput by over 80%. Similar cases show that enabling flow control and correcting duplex restored file transfer rates from 0.5 Mbps to over 20 Mbps. Microsoft also documents that zero-window stalls in SMB occur when the receiver's buffer is full, typically due to disk I/O delay.

3. Packet-Trace Analysis and Findings

3.1 Protocol Distribution

The trace is dominated by TCP over IPv4. Only one HTTP packet was captured, implying the issue focuses on a single TCP data session (likely file transfer).

Protocol	Percent Packets	Packets	Percent Bytes	Bytes	Bits/s	End Packets	End Bytes	End Bits/s	PDU's
Frame	100.0	7195	100.0	5564210	355 k	0	0	0	7195
Ethernet	100.0	7195	1.8	100772	6447	0	0	0	7195
Internet Protocol Version 4	100.0	7195	2.6	143900	9206	0	0	0	7195
Transmission Control Protocol	100.0	7195	2.9	159124	10 k	7194	159104	10 k	7195
Hypertext Transfer Protocol	0.0	1	0.0	445	28	1	445	28	1

Figure 1: Screenshot of Protocol Hierarchy

3.2 Conversations

This single stream demonstrates underutilized throughput (~0.35 Mbps) for a local gigabit-capable link, confirming performance degradation

Address A	Address B	Packets	Bytes	Stream ID	Packets A → B	Bytes A → B	Packets B → A	Bytes B → A	Rel Start	Duration
10.0.52.164	61.8.0.17	7,195	6 MB	0	3,652	213 kB	3,543	5 MB	0.000000	125.0464

Figure 2: Screenshot of conversations

3.3 Expert Information

Warnings detected:

- **TCP Zero Window segment** – Receiver cannot handle more data.
- **TCP window full** – Application not reading buffer.
- **Connection reset (RST)** – Session abruptly terminated.

- **Out-of-order segment** – Packets arrived out of sequence.

These indicate congestion, window exhaustion, and loss recovery. Frequent window full/zero events confirm bottlenecks in receiver-side processing.

Severity	Summary	Group
> Warning	Connection reset (RST)	Sequence
> Warning	TCP Zero Window segment	Sequence
> Warning	TCP window specified by the receiver is now completely full	Sequence
> Warning	This frame is a (suspected) out-of-order segment	Sequence
> Warning	Previous segment(s) not captured (common at capture start)	Sequence

Figure 3: Screenshot of expert information

3.4 I/O Graphs

The I/O Graph shows bursts of TCP errors and retransmissions at 0-25s and 50-100s, aligning with periods of stalled throughput. This pattern is consistent with transient congestion or duplex collisions.

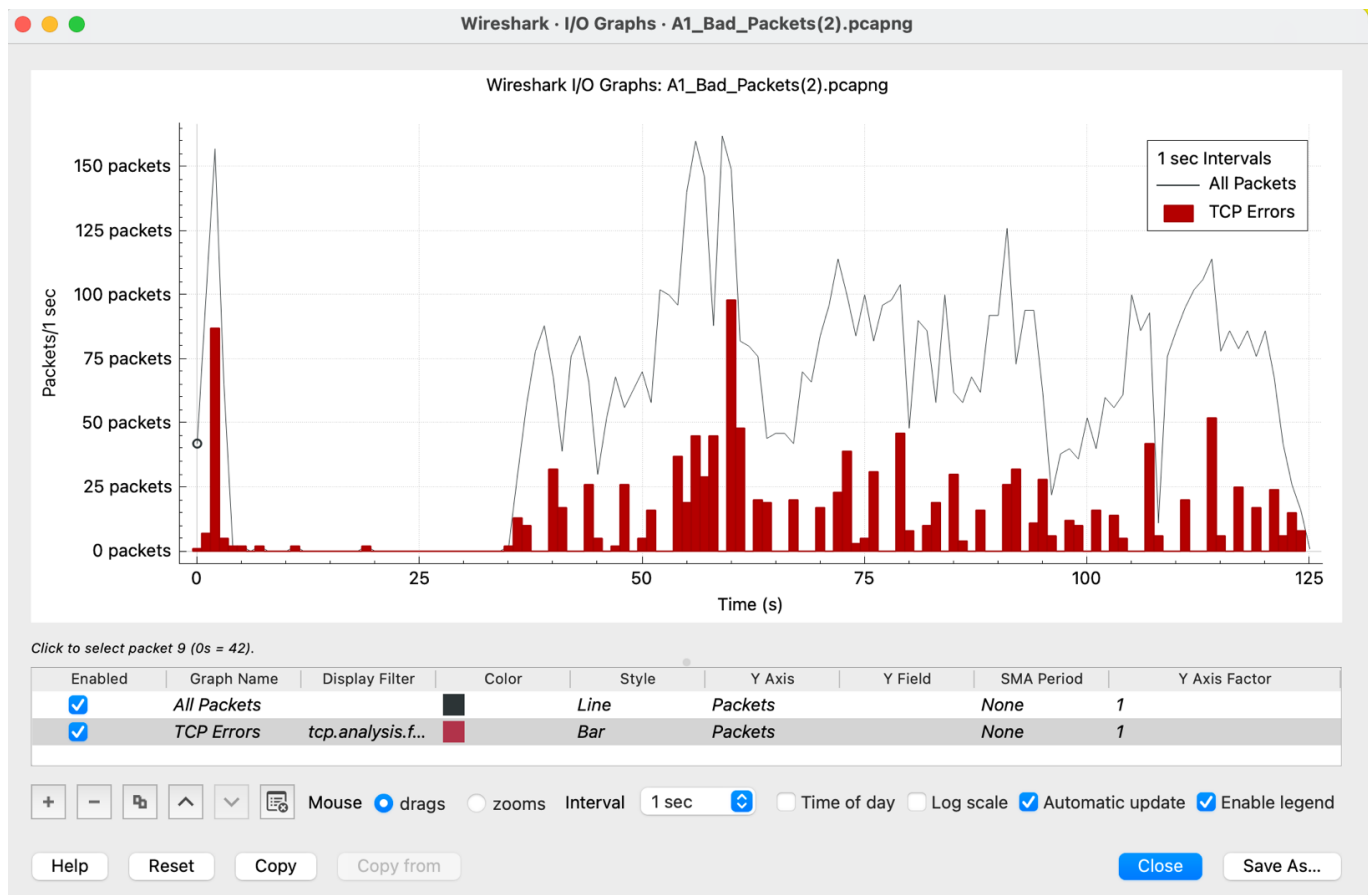


Figure 4: Screenshot of I/O Graphs

4. Root Cause Discussion

4.1 Primary Cause – Transport Layer Congestion and Retransmission

The capture reveals heavy TCP retransmissions and duplicate ACKSs consistent with packet loss. The throughput (~350 kbps) is significantly below expectation, confirming congestion or physical link issues. Retransmission bursts at 0-25s and 50-100s match error peaks.

4.2 Secondary Cause – Receiver Window Saturation

Multiple Zero Window and Window Full warnings show the receiver (61.8.0.17) frequently exhausted its buffer. This halts data flow until the buffer clears, explaining the slow file transfer rate.

4.3 Contributing Factor – Connection Resets

RST events cause the TCP session to restart, introducing further delay. This often occurs if an application (e.g., SMB) experiences timeouts due to slow acknowledgment.

5. Recommendations

Immediate Actions (Next 7 Days)

1. **Verify duplex and speed:** Ensure both NIC and switch operate at 1 Gbps full-duplex.
2. **Inspect cabling:** Replace patch cables and test for CRC errors.
3. **Check MTU consistency:** Ensure all network devices use MTU 1500; adjust if jumbo frames are used inconsistently.
4. **Stabilize DNS resolution:** Verify resolver response times and caching.

Short-Term Improvements (1-4 Weeks)

1. **Enable TCP window scaling:** Allow larger window size for high-latency links.
2. **Implement QoS policies:** Prioritize SMB and HTTP control traffic to prevent congestion.
3. **Monitor with SNMP:** Track interface errors, retransmission, and buffer utilization.

Long-Term Optimization (1-3 Months)

1. **Upgrade network infrastructure:** Deploy managed switches supporting flow control.
2. **Introduce performance dashboards:** Monitor retransmission %, zero-window events, and RTT over time.
3. **Educate IT staff:** Conduct routine packet analysis to catch early degradation.

6. Conclusion

The network's slow performance is attributed to a combination of **Transport layer congestion, receiver buffer exhaustion, and possible duplex mismatch**. Correcting physical and link configurations will immediately reduce retransmissions and improve throughput. In the longer term, tuning TCP parameters and implementing traffic prioritization will ensure consistent, high-speed performance.

7. Future Network Monitoring and Security Enhancement

To ensure sustainable performance and prevent similar issues in the future, BoredGames should adopt proactive network monitoring and layered security improvements. Continuous performance visibility allows early identification of congestion, link errors, or anomalous behaviors before users experience slowdowns.

7.1 Continuous Monitoring

Implement real-time monitoring tool such as Wireshark, SolarWinds, or PRTG Network Monitor to track throughput, error rates, and retransmissions. Automatic alerts can be

configured to notify administrators when thresholds are exceeded, such as retransmissions rates above 2% or increased TCP zero-window events.

7.2. Security Integration

Performance problems often correlate with security misconfigurations. Deploying intrusion detection systems (IDS), such as Snort or Zeek ensures both performance and security anomalies are captured. Additionally, regular vulnerabilities scans of routers and switches can identify outdated firmware or weak authentication settings.

7.3 Network Baseline and Documentation

Create a baseline of normal network behavior including latency, throughput, and application response time. Any deviation from the baseline will indicate developing issues. Proper documentation of topology, device configurations, and IP addressing will simplify troubleshooting in future incidents.

7.4 Long-Term Vision

In the long term, BoredGames could migrate to a Software-Defined Networking (SDN) model that provides centralized visibility and automated optimization. SDN controllers can dynamically reroute traffic to less congested paths, improving both reliability and scalability.

References

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